fact, we won all five Tests against the Windies – to date the only time the Proteas have registered a series whitewash.

After the King Commission had concluded, I saw Hansie once or twice at Fancourt Golf Estate, where he lived. But we didn't really stay in touch. Things were a little awkward between us, given what we had been through. Also, I was once again playing cricket after my six-month ban, but Hansie's cricket career was over. It was difficult.

All of us, his former teammates, were shocked when we learnt of the tragic circumstances of his death. At his funeral, I was sitting in front of Lance Klusener, who cried throughout the entire service. I held back my tears until they carried the coffin from the church … then I sobbed.

Hansie's life was tragic after the match fixing, but I'll say this much for him: the man was an inspirational cricket captain. The team we had was a proper team, not a bunch of individuals.

Gary Kirsten

Among all the players, I was probably closest to Gary Kirsten. He had a huge impact on my life – especially in my career. I wasn't a natural opening batsman, as my inclination was to be aggressive and hit the ball from the word go. But Gary helped me to curb my instincts somewhat and be more disciplined in my approach. Gary's work ethic is phenomenal and, through his example, I was motivated to put in the extra hours.

The two of us went through a lot out there in the middle. As opening partners we went through the same emotions, especially in Test cricket. It's not like Gary and I discussed a helluva lot of stuff, but when we walked out to the wicket together, we knew that we were having the same thoughts: how we felt when we were preparing for a Test match, as opposed to when we were actually walking out to face the world's fastest bowlers, who were all going to try to knock our bladdy heads off with the new ball.

Gary and I prepared for matches very intensely. We practised with the same intensity we had to face in a match, which meant that we were always ready for anything when we went out to bat. We used to take a new ball and throw it at each other from about 16 yards and bounce the living kak out of one another. Gary hit me on the helmet many times and, you know, I naturally returned the favour.

The practice sessions Gary and I had together were sometimes more draining than actually facing the bowlers in the middle – that's how hard we